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6 October 2026

Graduate Recruitment Team

Da Vinci Derivatives

Amsterdam, Netherlands

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Graduate Trader role in Amsterdam. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Da Vinci's focus on volatility, trading related derivatives against each other on the basis of their correlations, is close to the questions my dissertation asks about what drives volatility.

Most of what I am proudest of comes down to good decisions made with incomplete information. Playing 12 poker tables at once, I based every decision on expected value and set my stakes with the Kelly criterion, keeping at least 50 buy-ins because an edge estimated from my own results could be overstated. I also finished 14th at the Irish U19 Chess Championships in 2023 and won 21 of 22 games in a simultaneous exhibition against players with an average FIDE rating of 1860. As Vice-President and then President of the Strathclyde Poker Society, I ran weekly tournaments for around 60 players on a £600 budget per semester and taught new members to use the same method to work out how many buy-ins their own win rate, variance and risk tolerance call for.

I pair that instinct with quantitative work I can defend line by line. I built a Monte Carlo option pricer in which a geometric-Asian control variate cut the standard error of arithmetic-Asian estimates by 97% at 100,000 paths, and my dissertation tests whether sovereign oil hedges make petro-currencies' oil betas smaller, kinked or one-sided on OPEC announcement days, with a pre-registered test of whether what remains is tradable. Proprietary trading appeals to me because the feedback is immediate and impartial: every decision is priced, and improving means learning faster than the market. Nearly two years of busy bar shifts alongside full-time study, and now running the drinks programme as Head Mixologist at a new 200-cover Glasgow venue, have taught me to stay accurate when speed matters.

Da Vinci stands out to me because, as a firm founded in 2015, it is still small enough for graduate traders to own strategies, generate profit through position-taking and market making, and improve the firm's trading infrastructure. My dissertation studies how hedges reshape a price reaction into something smaller, kinked or one-sided, much like an option payoff, and my option pricer gave me a first-hand feel for how volatility feeds into value; I would like to develop both into trading judgement on Da Vinci's desks.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan